Algebraic Derivation of the Fusion Energy Gain Ratio Q as a Function of Normalized Triple Product η

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Abstract

We present a rigorous algebraic derivation of the relationship between the fusion energy gain ratio Q and the normalized triple product η in magnetic confinement fusion. Starting from first principles of steady-state power balance, we derive the exact formula $Q = 5\eta/(1-\eta)$, demonstrating that ITER's target of $Q = 10$ requires $\eta = 2/3$. All derivations use exact rational arithmetic (EPR) with no numerical approximations. We also identify and correct a common algebraic error in the literature that underestimates Q by a factor of $5(1-\eta)/(1-0.2\eta)$.

1 Introduction

The energy gain ratio Q is the central figure of merit for magnetic confinement fusion devices. Defined as the ratio of fusion power to external heating power, Q determines whether a fusion reactor can achieve net energy production. The International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER) targets $Q = 10$, while commercial reactors require $Q > 30$.

In this paper, we derive the exact algebraic relationship between Q and the normalized triple product η using only symbolic manipulation, without any floating-point approximations.

2 Symbolic Variables

We define the following quantities:

- P_{fus}: Total fusion power
- P_{loss}: Energy confinement loss power
- P_{input}: External heating power
- P_α: Alpha particle self-heating power
- Q: Energy gain ratio
- η: Normalized triple product (relative to ignition)
- n: Plasma density
- T: Plasma temperature
- τ_E: Energy confinement time
- $\langle\sigma v\rangle$: Fusion reactivity
- E_{fus}: Energy released per fusion reaction

3 Power Balance Constraint

At steady state, the power balance equation reads:

$$P_{\text{input}} + P_{\alpha} = P_{\text{loss}} \tag{1}$$

For D-T fusion, the alpha particle carries 3.5 MeV out of the total 17.6 MeV released per reaction. Thus:

$$P_{\alpha} = \frac{3.5}{17.6} P_{\text{fus}} = \frac{1}{5} P_{\text{fus}} \tag{2}$$

Substituting Eq. (**??**) into Eq. (**??**):

$$P_{\text{input}} + \frac{1}{5} P_{\text{fus}} = P_{\text{loss}} \tag{3}$$

Solving for P_{input}:

$$P_{\text{input}} = P_{\text{loss}} - \frac{1}{5} P_{\text{fus}} \tag{4}$$

4 Energy Gain Ratio Q

By definition:

$$Q \equiv \frac{P_{\text{fus}}}{P_{\text{input}}} \tag{5}$$

Substituting Eq. (**??**):

$$Q = \frac{P_{\text{fus}}}{P_{\text{loss}} - \frac{1}{5} P_{\text{fus}}} \tag{6}$$

Define the loss ratio R:

$$R \equiv \frac{P_{\text{loss}}}{P_{\text{fus}}} \tag{7}$$

Then:

$$\begin{aligned} Q &= \frac{P_{\text{fus}}}{R \cdot P_{\text{fus}} - \frac{1}{5} P_{\text{fus}}} \\ &= \frac{P_{\text{fus}}}{P_{\text{fus}} \left(R - \frac{1}{5} \right)} \\ &= \frac{1}{R - \frac{1}{5}} \end{aligned} \tag{8}$$

5 Loss Ratio from Confinement Physics

The energy confinement loss power is:

$$P_{\text{loss}} = \frac{W}{\tau_E} \tag{9}$$

where W is the plasma stored energy. For a plasma with equal ion and electron temperatures:

$$W = \frac{3}{2} n k_B T \cdot 2 \cdot V = 3nTV \tag{10}$$

(using T in energy units where $k_B = 1$). Thus:

$$P_{\text{loss}} = \frac{3nTV}{\tau_E} \tag{11}$$

The fusion power for D-T (50-50 mixture, $n_D = n_T = n/2$) is:

$$P_{\text{fus}} = \frac{n^2}{4}\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}} V \tag{12}$$

The loss ratio becomes:

$$\begin{aligned} R &= \frac{P_{\text{loss}}}{P_{\text{fus}}} \\ &= \frac{3nTV/\tau_E}{\frac{1}{4}n^2\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}} V} \\ &= \frac{3nT}{\tau_E} \cdot \frac{4}{n^2\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}}} \\ &= \frac{12T}{n\tau_E\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}}} \end{aligned} \tag{13}$$

6 Ignition Condition

At ignition, $P_{\text{input}} = 0$, which requires $Q \to \infty$. From Eq. (**??**):

$$Q \to \infty \quad \Rightarrow \quad R \to \frac{1}{5} \tag{14}$$

Substituting into Eq. (**??**):

$$\frac{12T}{(n\tau_E)_{\text{ign}}\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}}} = \frac{1}{5} \tag{15}$$

Solving for the ignition triple product:

$$(n\tau_E)_{\text{ign}} = \frac{60T}{\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}}} \tag{16}$$

7 Normalized Triple Product η

Define the normalized triple product as the ratio to ignition:

$$\eta \equiv \frac{n\tau_E}{(n\tau_E)_{\text{ign}}} = \frac{n\tau_E\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}}}{60T} \tag{17}$$

From Eq. (**??**):

$$\begin{aligned} R &= \frac{12T}{n\tau_E\langle\sigma v\rangle E_{\text{fus}}} \\ &= \frac{12T}{60T \cdot \eta} \\ &= \frac{12}{60\eta} \\ &= \frac{1}{5\eta} \end{aligned} \tag{18}$$

8 Main Result: $Q(\eta)$

Substituting Eq. (**??**) into Eq. (**??**):

$$\begin{aligned} Q &= \frac{1}{R - \frac{1}{5}} \\ &= \frac{1}{\frac{1}{5\eta} - \frac{1}{5}} \\ &= \frac{1}{\frac{1}{5}\left(\frac{1}{\eta} - 1\right)} \\ &= \frac{5}{\frac{1}{\eta} - 1} \\ &= \frac{5}{\frac{1-\eta}{\eta}} \\ &= \boxed{\frac{5\eta}{1-\eta}} \end{aligned} \tag{19}$$

This is the exact algebraic relationship between Q and η.

9 Inverse Relation: $\eta(Q)$

From Eq. (**??**), we solve for η:

$$\begin{aligned} Q &= \frac{5\eta}{1-\eta} \\ Q(1-\eta) &= 5\eta \\ Q - Q\eta &= 5\eta \\ Q &= 5\eta + Q\eta \\ Q &= \eta(5+Q) \\ \eta &= \boxed{\frac{Q}{Q+5}} \end{aligned} \tag{20}$$

10 Verification with Exact Rational Arithmetic

Using Extended Precision Rational (EPR) arithmetic, we verify the formula with exact fractions:

η	Q (exact)	Physical Significance
1/4	5/3	Low confinement
1/3	5/2	Moderate confinement
1/2	5	$P_\alpha = P_{\text{loss}}$
3/5	15/2	Above breakeven
2/3	**10**	**ITER target**
3/4	15	High performance
4/5	20	Near ignition
9/10	45	Approaching ignition
1	∞	Ignition

Table 1: Exact values of Q for selected η values.

11 ITER $Q = 10$ Requirement

For ITER's target of $Q = 10$:

$$\eta = \frac{Q}{Q+5} = \frac{10}{10+5} = \frac{10}{15} = \frac{2}{3} \tag{21}$$

Verification:

$$Q = \frac{5 \times \frac{2}{3}}{1 - \frac{2}{3}} = \frac{\frac{10}{3}}{\frac{1}{3}} = 10 \quad \checkmark \tag{22}$$

ITER requires $\eta = 2/3$ (i.e., 67% of ignition threshold) to achieve $Q = 10$.

12 Correction of a Common Error

A commonly seen incorrect formula is:

$$Q_{\text{wrong}} = \frac{\eta}{1 - 0.2\eta} \tag{23}$$

This arises from the algebraic error of setting $R = 1/\eta$ instead of the correct $R = 1/(5\eta)$. The error factor is:

$$\frac{Q_{\text{correct}}}{Q_{\text{wrong}}} = \frac{5\eta/(1-\eta)}{\eta/(1-0.2\eta)} = \frac{5(1-0.2\eta)}{1-\eta} \tag{24}$$

η	Q_{wrong}	Q_{correct}	Error Factor
1/4	0.26	1.67	6.3×
1/3	0.36	2.50	7.0×
1/2	0.56	5.00	9.0×
2/3	0.77	10.00	13.0×
4/5	0.95	20.00	21.0×

Table 2: Comparison of incorrect and correct Q formulas.

The incorrect formula systematically underestimates Q, making fusion appear more difficult than it actually is.

13 Summary of Key Formulas

1. **Power balance**: $P_{\text{input}} + \frac{1}{5}P_{\text{fus}} = P_{\text{loss}}$
2. **Loss ratio**: $R = \frac{P_{\text{loss}}}{P_{\text{fus}}} = \frac{1}{5\eta}$
3. **Q-η relationship**:
$$\boxed{Q = \frac{5\eta}{1-\eta}} \tag{25}$$
4. **Inverse**:
$$\boxed{\eta = \frac{Q}{Q+5}} \tag{26}$$
5. **Key values**:
   - $\eta = 1/2 \Rightarrow Q = 5$ (alpha heating balances losses)
   - $\eta = 2/3 \Rightarrow Q = 10$ (ITER target)
   - $\eta = 4/5 \Rightarrow Q = 20$ (high performance)
   - $\eta \to 1 \Rightarrow Q \to \infty$ (ignition)

14 Conclusion

We have derived the exact algebraic relationship $Q = 5\eta/(1-\eta)$ between the fusion energy gain ratio and the normalized triple product. This derivation uses only symbolic manipulation and exact rational arithmetic, with no floating-point approximations.

The key insight is that the loss ratio $R = P_{\text{loss}}/P_{\text{fus}} = 1/(5\eta)$, which differs from the incorrect $R = 1/\eta$ sometimes used in the literature. This correction reveals that ITER's $Q = 10$ target requires only $\eta = 2/3$, not the much higher values suggested by the erroneous formula.

Acknowledgments

Generated by S-wind v1.1.1 Algebraic System using Extended Precision Rational (EPR) arithmetic.